

[Return to Search](#)

Circumcision and excision ceremonies

Author(S): Kennedy, John G.

Document Type: Essay

Original Page: 161

Culture (OWC): [Nubians \(MR08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1964

Coverage Date: 1900 AD - 1964 AD

Place Coverage

northern Aswan Governate and Silwa, Red Sea Governate, Egypt

Section Title(S): Psychological Effects

Psychological Effects

In the Upper Egyptian village of Silwa, circumcision ceremonies show many similarities in meaning and content to those I have described for the nearby Nubians; Ammar (1954) has interpreted them psycho-functionally as means for "aligning the child with its sex group." He also proposes the supplementary psychological hypothesis that the operation and ritual help the child to identify with the parent of the same sex, while the drama makes him aware of the social implications and responsibilities of his sex role (1954, pp. 121, 124). Honigmann, commenting on the Silwa ceremonies as reported by Ammar, noticed that their timing coincides with the period of the first Oedipal crisis, and also that during everyday socialization, children are threatened with circumcision to induce obedience. He concludes that: "By this theory [i.e. using the concept of the Oedipal complex], threatening young children with genital mutilations and then carrying them out could be construed as taking advantage of a developmental stage to intensify and exploit such worries in order to enforce docility" (1967, p. 218).

171

[Comparative Evidence](#)

182

[Functional/Adaptational Interpretations](#)

304

[Body Alterations](#)

828

[Ethnopsychology](#)

834

[General Sex Restrictions](#)

Informants reported that this ritual complex often had a significant impact upon the attitudes and personalities of Nubian children, but enforcement of conformity seems a minor aspect of a complex set of influences. Most circumcisions in Old Nubia were performed between the ages of three and six, and as Honigmann noted, this is the "Oedipal" period — a stage of increased interest in the genitals, masturbation, exhibitionism, and aggression, when children frequently have fears concerning damage to the valued sex organ

124

[Interviewing In Research](#)

304

[Body Alterations](#)

828

and guilty fantasies about the mother. It is during this period, too, that much of the superego (conscience) formation is completed.

[Ethnopsychology](#)

[834](#)

[General Sex
Restrictions](#)

[861](#)

[Techniques Of
Socialization](#)

This critical period of sexual awakening, when the child is also mastering language, locomotion, and learning his potentialities for manipulating the environment, was just the time that the Nubians chose to traumatize him [162](#) with a genital operation. The operation forcefully and painfully drew his genital area to his attention. Particularly the male child could not help but be impressed by the great ceremonial drama centered upon him and specifically upon his sex organ. The numerous ritual precautions against *mushāhara* and evil jinns maintained awareness at high level, as did the congratulations and constant jokes concerning the operation.

[304](#)

[Body Alterations](#)

[831](#)

[Sexuality](#)

[834](#)

[General Sex
Restrictions](#)

[864](#)

[Sex Training](#)

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: [✉ hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs: [✉ hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)